

U1-002 Audio Transcript

Read Smart, Not Hard

Mark had an English reading test on Friday morning. As soon as he entered the classroom, he noticed that the test looked much longer than usual. There were three texts, several pages of questions, and only sixty minutes to finish everything.

At first, Mark felt nervous. He looked at the first article and thought, "There are too many words. I'll never finish this on time."

His teacher, Mrs. Green, noticed the worried faces of many students. Before the test officially started, she smiled and said, "Remember what we practised this week. Good readers don't begin by reading every single word. They read smart."

Those words helped Mark relax.

He looked at the title of the first article: "The Secret Life of Bees."

Instead of reading the whole article immediately, he spent a few seconds looking at the title, the pictures and the headings. He noticed words like flowers, honey, communication and environment.

"Okay," he thought. "This article is probably about how bees live and why they are important."

Without reading every sentence, he already understood the general topic. That was skimming.

Now Mark turned to the questions. One question asked, "How far can a bee travel in one day?"

Mark smiled. He didn't need to read the whole article again. He knew he was looking for a number.

His eyes moved quickly across the page until he found the sentence: "A bee may travel up to ten kilometres during a single day while searching for flowers."

He wrote the answer and continued. That was scanning.

For questions about facts, he used scanning. For questions about the main idea, he used skimming first and careful reading later.

During the break, his friend Daniel admitted that he had translated almost every word.

Mrs. Green explained that good readers know how to find information. They skim when they need the main idea and scan when they need specific details.

By the end of the month, Mark was reading faster, understanding more and feeling much more confident.

He realised that successful readers are not always the students with the biggest vocabulary. Very often, they are simply the students who know when to skim, when to scan, and when to read carefully.